

ANJUMAN COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGY (ACET), NAGPUR**Department of Civil Engineering (Open Elective offered to all branches)***Affiliated to Rashtrasant Tukadoji Maharaj Nagpur University (RTMNU)***INTRODUCTION TO VASTU SHASTRA (BOE5T03)**

B.Tech. | Semester V | Open Elective–III

UNIT – III : SITE SELECTION AND PLANNING PRINCIPLES*Student Notes – written in simple language for students of all branches*

Credits: 2	Lecture: 2 Hrs/Week	Internal: 30 University: 70	Unit-III Hours: 7 CO3
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What you should be able to do after this unit (CO3)

CO3 – Apply Vastu guidelines for site selection and residential planning. In plain terms: after this unit you should be able to look at a plot of land and judge whether it is good as per Vastu (its shape, size, slope, soil, road and surroundings), and you should be able to arrange the rooms of a simple house in the right directions.

Syllabus – Unit III

Shape and size of plot • Slope of land and soil conditions • Road position and site surroundings • Vastu guidelines for plot selection • Zoning of spaces as per Vastu.

A note before we start

This subject is an open elective, so you may be from any branch – mechanical, electrical, computer science, electronics, and so on. These notes assume that you have never studied building or construction before. Wherever a technical word is used, it is explained in plain language, and there is a short glossary at the end of these notes.

Vastu Shastra is a traditional Indian way of planning buildings. In this unit we simply learn how to use it to (1) choose a good plot of land, and (2) decide where each room of a house should go.

1. What is “site selection” and “planning”?

Site selection simply means **choosing a suitable plot of land** to build on. **Planning** means **deciding where each room and open space will go** on that plot. First you select the land, then you plan the building on it.

Why does the very first decision – which plot to choose – matter so much? Because almost everything else can be changed later, but the plot cannot. You can repaint a wall, move the furniture, even remove an inside wall. But you can never move the plot, its slope, or the direction it faces. So a good choice at the start saves a lot of trouble later.

In simple words

The whole idea of Vastu for a plot can be said in one line: let the gentle morning sunlight, fresh air and rainwater flow in from the North-East side, and keep the heavier, more closed part of the house towards the South-West side.

2. Shape and Size of the Plot

2.1 Shape of the plot

Regular shapes such as a square or a rectangle are preferred, because they are easy to plan, easy to build on, and use space fully. Irregular shapes (like a triangle or an L-shape) waste space and leave awkward corners, so they are avoided for a home.

- **Square** – the most ideal shape; all four sides and corners are balanced.
- **Rectangle** – also good, as long as it is not too long and thin (keep the length up to about twice the breadth).
- **Gomukhi (“cow-faced”)** – narrow at the front (the road side) and wider at the back. This shape is considered good for a house.
- **Shermukhi (“lion-faced”)** – wide at the front and narrow at the back. This shape suits shops and commercial buildings, but is not recommended for a home.
- **Corners** – a plot that sticks out a little at the North-East corner is considered lucky; a plot with the North-East corner cut off is avoided.

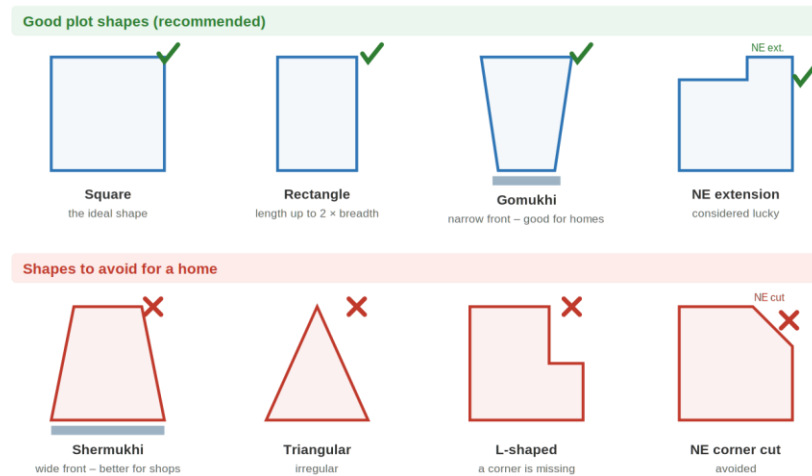


Fig. 3.1 Plot shapes – the ones Vastu recommends and the ones it avoids

In simple words

An easy way to remember Gomukhi and Shermukhi: a cow is narrow at the face and a lion is broad at the face. Gomukhi (cow) is narrow at the front – for homes. Shermukhi (lion) is wide at the front – for shops.

2.2 Size of the plot

- The plot should be large enough for the building, some open space around it, and the “setback” required by the local municipal rules.
- A shape close to a square, or a rectangle up to about 1 : 2 (length : breadth), is preferred. Very long, narrow strips are avoided.
- The corners should be right angles (90°) and the sides should face the main directions (North, South, East, West).

What is a “setback”?

A setback is the empty gap that the local municipal (city) rules force you to leave between your building and the edge of your plot – for example, 3 metres at the front and 1.5 metres on the sides. It is a legal rule (not a Vastu rule) that stops buildings from being packed right up to the boundary, and it leaves room for light, air and movement. You must always leave the required setback, whatever Vastu says.

3. Slope of the Land and Soil

3.1 Slope of the land

The **slope** of a plot is simply the direction in which the ground gently tilts. Vastu prefers a plot that is **higher on the South-West side and lower on the North-East side**, so that rainwater flows away naturally towards the North-East and leaves the plot there.

- Keep the ground higher in the South, South-West and West; lower in the North, North-East and East.
- Water should drain towards, and flow out from, the North-East.
- A slope the other way – where water collects in the South or South-West – is considered unfavourable.

In simple words

This is really just good drainage. You want rainwater to run away from the house, not to collect around it. It is like tilting a plate slightly so that water runs off one corner instead of pooling in the middle.

3.2 Soil (the ground you build on)

The soil decides how strong the ground is. Vastu describes “good” soil in simple, everyday terms, and modern building also checks it with proper tests done by experts.

- **Vastu’s description of good soil:** firm, of pleasant colour, sweet-smelling, and free of buried rubbish, bones or pits.
- **What engineers additionally check:** the “bearing capacity” of the soil, the type of soil, and how high the underground water is.

What is “bearing capacity”?

Bearing capacity means how much weight the soil can safely carry without sinking or giving way. Firm ground (like hard soil, gravel or rock) has a high bearing capacity and is strong; soft, loose or marshy ground is weak. Engineers test this before construction. Remember: Vastu’s “good soil” description is only a first impression – the real decision about the foundation is made by testing, not by smell or colour.

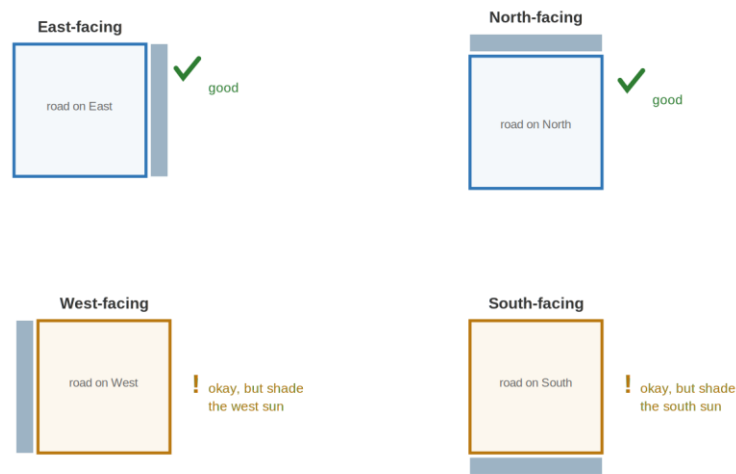
4. Road Position and Surroundings

4.1 Which side is the road on? (the “facing” of a plot)

The side on which the approach road lies decides the “facing” of the plot – and usually where the main gate and entrance will be.

- **Road on the North or East** – favourable. The entrance and windows then fall on the bright, cool morning side.

- **Road on the South or West** – acceptable, but you should shade those hot sides and plan the entrance with care.
- **Corner plot with roads on both North and East** – considered the best of all.



A corner plot with roads on the North and East sides is considered the best of all.

Fig. 3.3 The "facing" of a plot depends on which side the road is

4.2 Surroundings (what is around the plot)

- Open space, a water body, or lower ground on the North-East side is good.
- Tall buildings, hills or heavy structures are better on the South-West side.
- Keep the area right in front of the main door clear – no big pole, tree or obstruction.
- Avoid plots next to unpleasant neighbours such as dumping grounds, burial grounds or heavy, polluting industry.
- Also check the basic practical things: proper road access, drainage, electricity and water supply.

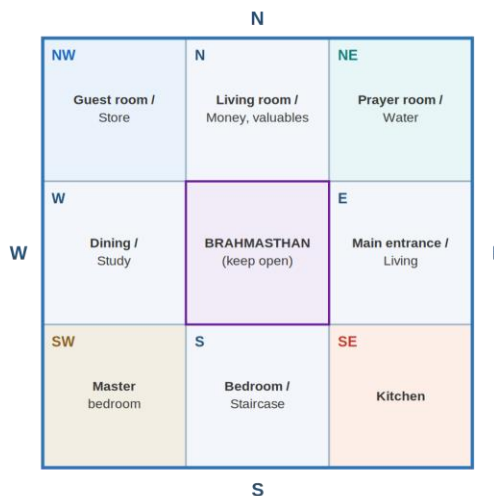
5. A Simple Checklist for Choosing a Plot

The points above can be put together as a quick checklist. A plot that meets most of these is considered good as per Vastu for a home.

What to look at	The favourable choice
Shape	Square, rectangle or Gomukhi; regular shape with square corners.
Corners	North-East may extend outward; the North-East corner must not be cut.
Slope	Higher on the South-West side, lower on the North-East; water drains to the NE.
Soil	Firm and clean ground (and, for real building, tested by engineers).
Road / facing	Road on the North or East is best; a North-East corner plot is ideal.
Surroundings	Open / low / water to the North-East; tall structures to the South-West.
Size	Big enough for the building plus open space and the required setback.

6. Room Layout (Zoning) of a House

Zoning simply means **deciding which room goes in which direction**. The simple rules of thumb are: keep the North-East light and open, put the kitchen (fire) in the South-East, put the heaviest and most private rooms in the South-West, and keep the very centre of the house open.



Heavy / closed rooms to the S-SW • light / open to the N-NE • centre kept free

Fig. 3.2 A Vastu room layout (zoning) for a simple house

The recommended place for each room is given below:

Direction	Suggested room / use
North-East	Prayer room and water source (tank, borewell); kept light and open.
East	Main entrance, living room; gets the morning sun.

Direction	Suggested room / use
South-East	Kitchen (the “fire” direction) and electrical/heating equipment.
South	Bedroom, staircase; fewer openings.
South-West	Master bedroom and heavy storage – the most stable, private corner.
West	Dining room, study or children’s room.
North-West	Guest room, store, garage – and the toilet, if needed.
North	Living room; money and valuables (the “wealth” direction).
Centre	Brahmasthan – kept open and free of clutter, toilets and heavy pillars.

Two rules about services (kitchen & toilet) that students often forget

- Do not place a toilet in the North-East or in the centre of the house; use the North-West or other suitable spot.
- Do not place the kitchen and toilet right next to each other, or one directly above/below the other (this is also good hygiene).

7. A Balanced View – Tradition and Common Sense

As a thinking student, it helps to see Vastu on two levels.

- **Ideas that make plain, practical sense:** facing the gentle morning sun, letting fresh air flow through the house, draining rainwater away from the building, and keeping the centre open and airy. Anyone can understand these as comfort and health reasons – they are simply good design.
- **Ideas that belong to tradition and belief:** lucky and unlucky directions, presiding deities, and prayers before building. These are part of the culture and are respected, but they are not proven by science.

Important for anyone who designs or builds

Vastu is a helpful guideline, not a rulebook that comes before the law. It must never override safety rules and government (municipal) building rules. If a Vastu idea clashes with a safety code or a municipal rule – for example, the required setback, fire safety, or a structural design – the rule always comes first. Respect Vastu where it does no harm, and follow the codes always.

Quick Revision (at a glance)

Key points to remember

- **Shape:** square (ideal) or rectangle; Gomukhi for homes; avoid Shermukhi, triangular, L-shaped and NE-cut plots.
- **Slope:** higher in the South-West, lower in the North-East; rainwater drains to the North-East.
- **Soil:** firm and clean – but the real strength (bearing capacity) is decided by testing.
- **Road / facing:** road on the North or East is best; a North-East corner plot is ideal.
- **Surroundings:** open / low / water to the North-East; tall structures to the South-West; clear entrance.
- **Zoning:** prayer/water in the North-East, kitchen in the South-East, master bedroom in the South-West, centre kept open.
- **Services:** no toilet in the North-East or centre; keep the kitchen and toilet apart.
- **Golden rule:** Vastu is a guideline; safety codes and municipal rules always come first.

Glossary of Terms (plain meanings)

Term	Simple meaning
Plot	A piece of land on which a building is built.
Site selection	Choosing a suitable plot of land.
Planning	Deciding where each room and space goes on the plot.
Orientation	The direction a building or room faces.

Term	Simple meaning
Facing	The side of a plot on which the main road (and usually the entrance) lies.
Setback	The gap you must legally leave between the building and the plot boundary (a municipal rule).
Slope	The direction in which the ground gently tilts.
Drainage	Letting rainwater flow away so it does not collect around the building.
Bearing capacity	How much weight the soil can safely carry without sinking; found by testing.
Ventilation	The free flow of fresh air through a building.
Brahmasthan	The central zone of a house, kept open and clutter-free.
Cardinal directions	The four main directions: North, East, South and West.
Gomukhi plot	A plot narrow at the front and wide at the back (good for a home).
Shermukhi plot	A plot wide at the front and narrow at the back (better for a shop).
Bye-laws	The local government (municipal) rules that every building must follow.

Practice Questions (CO3)

Short-answer / objective

1. Which plot shape is considered ideal in Vastu, and why?
2. What is the difference between a Gomukhi and a Shermukhi plot? Which one is preferred for a house?
3. In which direction should the plot be higher, and in which direction lower? Why?
4. Which side is the best position for the approach road?
5. Where should the kitchen, the prayer room and the master bedroom be placed?

Long-answer

6. Explain, with simple sketches, the plot shapes that Vastu recommends and the ones it avoids.
7. Describe the Vastu guidelines for selecting a plot (shape, slope, soil, road and surroundings).
8. Draw a simple Vastu room layout (zoning) for a house and explain the position of each room.
9. "Vastu is a helpful guideline, but building rules always come first." Discuss this statement with examples.

Reference Books

1. B. Niranjan Babu, Vastu Shastra – Principles and Applications, Vastu Vijnan Prakashan, New Delhi.
2. Dr. Bhojraj Dwivedi, Vastu Shastra for Modern Homes, Diamond Books, New Delhi.
3. Ashok B. Jain, Practical Vastu Shastra, Sterling Publishers Pvt. Ltd., New Delhi.